Yearning, Learning

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/47268280.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

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by vidrioborroso

Summary

A series of Catradora shorts based on a 30-day Pride Month prompts list.

While this collection will mainly depict sweet and fluffy moments between the two, the occasional sentimental one might drop in every once in a while.

Storm

Prompts List Credit

The weight of everything that's happened dawns upon Catra right as the heavy night falls. She suppresses those feelings by hugging her knees to her chest and closing her eyes. Then, she takes a breath, a shudder making her body tremble after she lets it go. The thought of how close she was to losing Adora arrives time after time in her thoughts. Even the simplest glance at something remotely familiar greets her with nostalgia and a bitter taste to her mouth.

"Catra?"

Her girlfriend's voice makes her tail shoot up, the same applying to her ears. It's only when she spots her that relief gets to her. Hearing her voice but not being able to see her made for her fears to rise up and manifest themselves again.

"Can't sleep?"

She relaxes some more at the feeling of Adora's hands over her shoulders. Her eyes close again, this time in ease, and she manages a smile, letting her tension dissipate with a sigh. "Yeah," she murmurs, cuddling up to her. "Everything feels so…" Catra fails to find the right words to answer her with, so she makes up for it by hugging the one close to her, pressing her face to her chest as she finds more composure through another exhale. "None of this feels real," she adds, completing her sentence. "I'm scared it'll end as soon as I go to bed."

Hearing Adora suppress a laugh, she pulls back and faces her, welcomed by her smile. "You're not alone," she says, kissing her forehead. "I haven't slept either because of that."

An idea reaches Catra's mind, one she's not sure whether to voice out loud or not. Hesitating, she scoots back closer to her

girlfriend’s side, grabbing her shirt and forcing herself to meet with her eyes again. “Wanna go outside?” Her heart quickens its pace as she waits for a response; her hands begin to sweat, prompting her to pull away again, not wanting to make her worry more than she had already. “We can go for a walk togethe-”

“That’s a great idea!” Adora shouts, quiet enough not to wake those nearby. Her sudden burst of excitement allows Catra to smile again, confidence returning. “What place do you have in mind?”

Her smile grows, and her mouth voices a quick reply, “I was thinking a walk around the garden.” She stops to glance at the window, taking a peek of the outside world. “Or pretty much any place, so long as you’re with me.”

Again, she hears Adora laugh, a sound almost melodic to her ears. She grins and nudges her on the waist, joining in on her merriment. “What?” she asks, chuckling. “I’m serious, Adora!”

“I know you are,” the blonde replies, in between giggles. “You’re just too cute when you say stuff like that."

Warmth rises over Catra’s face, and she can only respond to her girlfriend’s teasing by faking annoyance and taking her by the hand. She holds her tight and tugs for her to follow along, steps careful as they both make their way out. When she feels Adora return the gesture by squeezing her hand back, Catra freezes, though she still tries to recover quickly from it, not wanting to be caught.

“I love you.”

This time, she can’t avoid stopping. Her gaze faces Adora’s, seeing a smile far too fond and bright for her heart to handle. She smiles back, though it takes her some time to snap out of it.

“I love you, too.”

Rainbow

Peace has become a strange and generally otherworldly thing for Catra to experience now that it's all falling into place. Without needing to stay on-guard around Shadow Weaver, impress Hordak, or submit herself to Prime's demands, a heavy weight's finally lifted off her shoulders. Regardless, she still can't forget over those moments, nor ignore the flashes from when she once used to be chipped. While the device is gone as so are two of those people occupying her thoughts, her memories are still fresh, and it's hard for her not to keep them in mind as she sits down on the grass, the scent of flowers distinctive in the air.

Adora joins her side and rests her head on her shoulder. Their hands interlock with each other as they stare at the sky, a countless amount of stars presenting themselves amongst the clouds. Catra tries closing her eyes to relax, yet as soon as she does, unwanted thoughts return to her mind. She grits her teeth and fights them back, something Adora seems to notice, based on how she sits up straighter and makes her face her side. "Still can't sleep?" she asks, cupping her cheek.

Catra nods and lets out a hum, ears drooping before she can get to reply, "Wanna walk around some more?"

Her girlfriend agrees with a 'sure' and stands up first, helping her back to her feet with the stretch of an arm. She takes it and keeps her hold on it as they both set off for another walk. She's lost track of time, and she's pretty sure Adora has, too, though neither of them comment over the matter. The sun's already beginning to show over the horizon, giving some awareness over how late, if not how early it now was.

"How do you feel about…" Catra stops just as she's about to say the woman's name. Her breath hitches and her chest tightens, unabling her from continuing. She holds Adora's hand stronger and tries to seek peace with a deep, steady breath, still

wanting to finish her question. "How do you feel about… Shadow Weaver not being here anymore?"

Adora stops in her tracks. She looks towards her, managing an expression between sorrow and a smile. "I'm…" Her hand squeezes Catra's back, a subtle tremble present in that movement. "I guess I haven't thought too much about it yet." She huffs and closes her eyes, opening them when her shoulders fall. "It just feels strange knowing she's not here anymore, and… I guess even stranger when I'm not sure over what to feel."

A pause follows after that and she lets go of Catra's hand. At that, Catra stops and meets with her gaze. "What about you?" her girlfriend asks.

She's not sure over how to voice her response, her's similar to Adora's, though not as clearly worded as she wanted it to be. Now that she was free from having to impress others and trying too hard to maintain her status, she could concentrate more on who she wanted to be and what she wanted to do, rather than going along with what once used to be imposed on her. One of those things is dedicating more quality time with Adora, though she's not exactly willing to admit that right now.

To make up for her inability of saying what's on her mind, she takes Adora by the arm and pulls her closer. A small smile forms on her lips, and she sees her girlfriend return it with a warmer one. She gives her's a quick peck, an action she deepens the second Adora kisses back.

"I think I feel the same way," Catra replies, pulling her in for a hug. "You know me well, Adora."

First Date

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

For an official first date of sorts, the pair decide to keep things simple, though they still make an effort to dress up. While Adora wears a dress and Catra a suit, the two share one thing in common, and that's the color red. They're both in formal wear and ready to head over to the beach. With how peaceful things have become and how much time of leisure summer offers, distracting themselves was not only a choice, but a necessity for the sake of their well-being. Having *too* much free time would only result in further gloom and worrying over too much at once.

For once, it would do the pair good to simply enjoy a day at the beach. The farewell of the sun allows them to find shelter in the moonlight and enjoy their surroundings without the necessity of sunblock. Taking a walk by the beach under the light of the moon while dressed in formal wear sounded like the most obnoxiously romantic first date they could come up with, but neither of the two women comment on the matter.

Instead, they step into the beach without worries. Catra stretches by the sand while Adora hikes the skirt of her dress up to her knees, keeping it from touching the water. She soaks her feet and invites Catra to join in. "The water's warm," she says, smiling. "Come on!" She gestures her over with the wave of her free hand, widening her smile when she sees her girlfriend give in and approach the water.

Catra kneels down and rolls the ends of her suit's pants, folding them twice before getting back up on her feet. She's confident throughout, though by the time she makes it to the edge, she grows reluctant to touch the tides. Netossa was right about her being afraid of water, but only to an extent. While she could approach the rain and shower without a problem, deep bodies of water scared her away, as so did water below room temperature. Her eyes meet with Adora's, who reassures her over the warmth of the water with a nod. She goes as far as to offer out a hand to her, keeping it outstretched until Catra finds the courage to take it and dip a foot into the ocean.

"Do it slowly," Adora suggests, holding her hand tighter. She lets her other hand be free by allowing her dress's skirt to fall back down, touching the water. When she sees Catra's about to protest, she assures her it's fine. "It's just the two of us, anyway," she adds, letting out a laugh. "And we're pretty much just dressed like this for fun! It doesn't matter."

Catra eases into those words. Her ears droop and she smiles, nodding as she dips her other foot in the water. "...Thanks," she mutters, embarrassment dwelling on her cheeks. She tries not to let Adora see by facing down, yet judging by how the blonde giggles, Catra figures she's already been found out. A shudder takes her over the second a gust of wind blows by, something Adora counters by slipping a hand around her waist and pulling her close. "Was this just an excuse for you to do that? she asks, facing Adora.

The one in question laughs, shrugging as her eyes wander elsewhere. "Maybe," she replies, kissing her cheek.

"Hey!" Catra's protest is weak as she dissolves into laughter. She tackles her girlfriend down against the sand, careful enough not to hurt her. As payback, she kisses her back on both her cheeks, intentionally ticklish ones to double the strength of her actions.

Chapter End Notes

Forgot to mention this earlier, but...

Updates will be twice a week on Thursdays and Fridays!

The full/detailed schedule of all my works can be found on my profile.

Identity

She erases the sentence for a fifth time in a row. The paper breaks with how worn it's become, obliging her to crush it into a ball and throw it in the bin nearby. She huffs and lays her head down, giving up for just a second. A moment of peace was needed to clear out her thoughts and try to write that letter again.

When she hears footsteps from nearby, she pretends to be asleep, not wanting Adora to grow concerned over her delays nor her progress. Apologizing was harder the more she let her thoughts run, and it was harder still doing it through a piece of paper. While she had the opportunity to erase and redo it as many times as she would like, that was the very same reason why she'd rewritten the letter that many times. She wasn't getting anywhere, and she's sure frustration's not far behind.

"I know you're pretending, Catra," her girlfriend says, kissing her ear lobe. "Show me what you have so far," she grabs her shoulder, giving it a reassuring squeeze. "I can help you out."

Conflicted, she huffs and opens her eyes, facing Adora with a wary gaze. "It's supposed to be my job," she replies, passing a hand through her hair, still short, but having grown just a few inches longer during her time spent at Bright Moon. "I can't just let you apologize for me!"

"And I *won't,"* she persists, letting her arm go. "I'll just read what you have and tell you if anything could use improvement." The blonde sits herself next to Catra, picking up the few letters she's actually managed to complete. Three are already piled out, though she still has quite a few more to go. So far, each person she had in mind to apologize to had been difficult in one way or the other. She couldn't say there was anyone in particular that resulted easy for her to write to. Her next two targets were Scorpia and Entrapta, the both of them she couldn't write for without rewriting her sentences again and again.

"Maybe you should take a break for today?" Adora suggests, seeing her at the ready: a sharpened pencil in her hand and a new sheet of paper on the table. "Three a day sounds good. You don't need to write them all at once if you want to be honest with everyone." She rubs her back, soothing her into calm. "'Cause then you wouldn't be able to if you're already worn out."

Catra shakes her head and sets the pencil aside, frowning all the while. Then, she pinches the bridge of her nose and lets out a breath. When she's sure she's regained some composure, she speaks up, "I can't." She grabs the pencil again, tapping it against the table's wooden surface. "I feel like I'm wasting time the more I erase and do it all over again."

"And that's *exactly* why you should rest." Adora holds her shoulder tighter, offering her more support as she then hugs her from behind. "You've been sitting here for five hours already, and it's almost midnight."

The brunette's ears droop as she considers those words. She checks the time on the wall clock nearby, seeing eleven thirty marked with its arrows. From what her hazy mind remembered, she'd sat down at exactly six in the evening and hadn't bothered to so much as have a drink of water for a break. A few crumpled paper balls are scattered around the room, having fallen and strayed away in the process of her arduous letter writing. There's pencil shavings on her desk, some sticking to her arm and staining her fur.

"...Should I?" she asks, reluctant.

Adora nods, hugging her tighter as she lets out a sigh, a smile showing through. "You should. I'm tired already, and I want you to make me company."

A laugh slips from Catra's mouth, one she tries to cover up by humming and looking away from her side. She grins, grabbing her girlfriend's hand before speaking up. "Grown used to having me around the room, huh?"

She nods once more, letting go of her to turn her around and kiss her lips quickly. "You're good to cuddle with."

Modern AU

When she sees Adora cover up a yawn, Catra figures it's time to try to convince her into catching a break. "Want to go get some food?" she suggests, placing her hands on her shoulders, "You've been here for three hours now."

The blonde closes her book and sets it aside, a hand bringing itself over her forehead and another on Catra's left one. She sighs, a smile showing after it. "Would it be okay, though?" Then, she frowns, letting Catra's hand go. "It just feels like I haven't studied enough yet."

"C'mon," the brunette persists, nudging her shoulders. "You've got two whole months. That's plenty of time!" To further ease matters out, Catra rubs her cheek against Adora's, fur tickling the latter's face and driving out a few giggles from her. "I'm sure you'll do good, but burning yourself out like this'll get you nowhere." She lets her shoulders go and plops down on the chair next to hers, a hand now placing itself on her shoulder. "How about it? There's a coffee shop right by the corner."

She can see Adora hesitate for just a moment, her shoulders drooping along with her frown. Her gaze scrunches up, forming lines on her forehead. "You'll get old ahead of time if you keep thinking it too much."

Thankfully, that's enough teasing to get her out of her stump. She stands up, glares, and chases after her, although quietly. It's a silent pursuit, with Catra dodging chairs and tables while Adora tries her best on doing the same thing. Trained and skilled as she was, the brunette was still more agile than her, her feline genes helping even things out between them. The romp continues until they both reach the door, being shushed by the librarian the second the bells chime too loud, their exit the least graceful of their chase.

The two women burst into laughter as soon as the door closes. Adora slumps against a wall while Catra crouches down, taking a moment to compose themselves. Ten minutes pass, and they're ready to go, the scents of coffee and pastries caught when they finally snap out of the leftover adrenaline from the run. The blonde helps her girlfriend up with the stretch of a hand, keeping her hold on her as they make way to the shop. Sun shines over them as they walk, the clouds parting with the strong wind that blows past. Rain warns to arrive with the droplets they can feel against their skin, these cold to the touch.

"Wanna run for it?" Adora suggests, aware of Catra's dislike of water beyond that of showering and soaking her feet at the beach.

Surprisingly, she shakes her head, a smile forming when she winks at her. "I'm fine," she says, grasping her hand stronger. "It feels nicer when I'm with you." There's a pause in her words, her continuation making matters less romantic. "That, and I'm kinda tired out by what we did back there."

Adora laughs, replying with, "...Same here."

They both share a grin and a bursted chuckle, minds thinking the same thing. "We're kinda letting ourselves go, aren't we?" Catra comments, letting her hand go when they both make it to the coffee shop. "In training, I mean."

With how peaceful things had become, training had lost its frequency. Now, they only did it for fun and for old times sake. "I think we are," Adora replies, smile widening. She holds the door for her, sweet scents augmenting as they step in. "But it's been a nice change of pace. Even with college looming over… I like the new life we have now."

Catra nods, pressing a quick kiss to her lips right before approaching the ordering counter. "I think so, too."

Discovery

Although her past home was one she'd rather forget, there's stuff she doesn't mind keeping, one of these being pictures where she could be seen spending time with Adora. She's treasured them all in one box, this one kept a secret from the blonde. Today though, as she stares at a picture from when they were along the ages of five and seven, she wonders if it would be good to show them to her. She holds the picture for a while, hiding it back in the box when she hears footsteps from nearby.

"Ready to go?" Adora asks, emerging at the door. The attire she's wearing reminds Catra over where her girlfriend needed to head to, the formality of her outfit giving away most of it.

She takes a subtle look at her own attire, only missing some shoes. "Just a second," she replies, smiling at her before going off to her closet. From there, she retrieves a pair and slides them on, moving on quickly with tying them when she sees Adora take interest in the box she'd left unattended. With wide eyes, she stands up and rushes back to her side, arriving just a bit too late.

She sees her smile and a laugh's quick to accompany it, left to watch as she takes a picture and faces Catra with an amused gaze. "How long did you have these for?" she asks, tone the same. "I thought we'd lost most of them!"

Knowing it's a lost battle, the brunette gives in with a sigh, a hint of a smile making its way to her lips. She joins Adora and takes one from the collection, now ending up with a picture from when they were reaching their pre-teens. Years had passed since the first picture she focused on, and now this one, but they still had each other. Her eyes water at that thought, and for a moment, relief washes over her like a tide on a warm day. Now that almost a whole year had gone by since they were reunited, she found it hard to believe they had once been separated, and in ways as extreme as they had been. She's thankful Bright Moon has kept

itself peaceful and that she could still see Adora whenever she looked for her.

It wasn't a dream.

"Thank you for saving these," she hears her girlfriend say, bringing her out of those thoughts. She faces her side, a fond gaze replacing her amused one. "I didn't think they'd survive."

Catra's smile reappears as she nods and takes Adora's hand. She tugs her closer, a movement gentle enough to go unnoticed. Even so, Adora smiles and steps forward, pulling her into a hug. "...N-No problem," Catra says, tears showing in her voice. Despite having tried her best not to let those show in her eyes, they'd escaped through her mouth, prompting Adora to hug them away. "They were still good memories, even with the place we were living them in."

She rests her face against her girlfriend's chest, a tiny laugh bursting through when she hears her sneeze, hair responsible for it. "Did my hair tickle you, or are you getting allergic to me?" she teases, face still hidden against her chest.

Adora sniffles, chuckling after. "A bit of both, I think."

Her confession makes the two of them laugh, helping Catra manage better with the weight of the memories still making rounds through her head. They were fresh in her mind, but there was nothing quite like getting to see them in pictures. Even with the emotions they brought back, she was still grateful to have kept them, and even more now, knowing her girlfriend felt the same way.

Hopefully, one day, she would look at them again without letting the more negative and unwanted side of her memories take over her.

Underwater

While Catra would rather avoid water bodies reaching deeper than her knees, the awe on Adora's face was too grand for her to brush it off just like that. She'd swallowed up her fears when making the decision, and had controlled the quick beat of her heart when booking a stay at that hotel. Money was no trouble and neither was time, but the simple thought of having to spend a full night or two underwater made her fur spike, even if the room was protected by a thick and sturdy dome. It takes all her might setting those worries aside to focus on packing up, and it's almost impossible for her not to jump when she hears someone open the door. She breathes in, readies herself, and catches onto the distinctive sight of Adora's hair when looking behind her. On instinct, the brunette shuts her travel bag despite it still being half empty and faces her girlfriend's side, who's already casting a wary, if not accusatory look at her.

"Are you sure you can do this?" she asks, narrowing her gaze and letting a frown show through. "You don't have to force yourself for it." When Catra doesn't answer, the blonde smiles, flares her nostrils, and a hand reaches out for her cheek, grazing her fur. "We can go somewhere else."

Catra shakes her head, saying, "It's fine." She returns her girlfriend's smile with a grin and takes the hand holding her face. "It looks cool. I just need to get used to it." Then, she squeezes her hand, a fonder gaze reaching her eyes. "...You inspired me to do it with how dumbstruck you looked back then."

Adora chuckles, flicking one of Catra's ears and later poking her tongue out at her. "Don't you mean awestruck?" she retorts, gaze scrutinizing her.

"No." She shakes her head, a giggle bursting through that sole word. "You looked *seriously* dumb back then, and you still do whenever you see pictures of that place."

To defend her pride, Adora feigns betrayal and throws a pillow at her, though the latter manages to catch in right on time. The second time though, giving no time for her to recover, she succeeds in her throw, hitting Catra right on her face.

She laughs as she sees her topple and fall off the bed, reaching the floor with a dull thump.

“I’m starting to reconsider my choices,” Catra hisses, feigning anger as she bares her fangs at her.

“Good,” the blonde says, nodding as she faces down at her, standing up and with her hands placed firm on her hips, displaying her triumph. “You should. I know it's necessary to fight your fears every once in a while, but booking a stay at an underwater hotel's definitely *not* the way to go about it."

Catra huffs, taking Adora's hand when having it offered out to her. She sits up again, ears droopy and lips downcast. "I wanted this to be special."

"As long as we're both happy, anywhere's perfect."

Disregarding how corny that sentence is, Catra smiles and pulls her girlfriend in for a quick hug.

"Thanks," she says, chuckling. "But I still want to do this with you."

Elevator

The longer Catra has to wait for the elevator to arrive, the more nervous she gets. Her fur stands on edge as so does her tail, though she retrieves some calm when facing to her left, seeing who's accompanying her. Adora stands by with a travel bag held up over her arm and a smile pasted to her face. She looks too happy for her to interrupt that moment for her, so Catra chooses to keep quiet and distracts herself with the decor laying around.

She labels that as a bad move the moment she stares through one of the windows, displaying an underwater world barely inches away from her feet. What kept her from touching the water was a thin floor and nothing more, making people wobble slightly whenever there were too many walking around at once. It's even worse when she thinks about the elevator she's about to get into, remembering the pamphlet she'd seen with Adora and how it was a clear tube that led them to the hotel rooms.

Just as the elevator arrives, she feels Adora's hand slip over hers, holding it tight. She doesn't look towards her when Catra decides to face her side, though she can catch her smile from the corner of her eye. She steps in with the brunette and squeezes her hand stronger, reassuring her once more.

When they enter, Catra's not as fearful as she thought she would be. Holding onto the blonde's hand helps, and having her pressed close aids her even more, giving her the opportunity to rest her head on her shoulder and wait while they go down. It's a different experience when it begins to move, though Adora continues to show attentiveness, this time resorting to letting go of her hand and wrapping an arm around her waist, bringing her even closer than before.

Catra's heart finds calm again. More at ease, she lets herself find comfort in the experience and observes as they lower

further, up until the elevator stops and announces it with a ding.

"Thank you," she murmurs, locking her arm with Adora's.

Adora smiles, winking at her. She doesn't say anything and instead lets go of her, using both arms to carry her bridal style.

"Let me know if you want me to put you down," she elaborates, giving context to her actions, "But right now, I think it's better if I do this."

To further explain what she means, she points with her chin towards the path laid out before them, displaying a hallway made out of glass and the ocean world under it.

Catra's breath hitches and she finds herself nodding. She grits her teeth, huffs out her tension, and grabs Adora by placing her arms around her shoulders, keeping herself held up by her. "Keep going," she assures her, voice faint. "I'll… I'll tell you when I'm ready."

The blonde nods, taking caution not to let Catra slip from her hold when she begins walking, glass tapping under the soles of her boots.

It's another calmer experience for Catra, not having to touch the floor but being able to see what's under it helping with the first step in battling her fear. She nuzzles her face against Adora's neck and closes her eyes when she's gotten used to it. Then, she lets out a breath, releasing her tension through it.

Closet

While Catra showers, Adora begins unpacking, hanging every clothing piece she brought along with how short the stay would be and how massive the wardrobe in front of her is, providing more than enough space and hangers for both her and her girlfriend to use. She stops when picking out a particular outfit: a short-sleeved dress reaching right below her knees and with a low cut in the back. It's matched up with a thin shawl for her shoulders, along with the only other pair of shoes she brought aside from her current ones: a simple pair of low-heel sandals, leaving her dress to stand out the most from it all. She sets her outfit aside and hangs the rest of the clothes left, finishing just as water stops running, hinting at Catra being close to finish showering.

Having little time left, the blonde acts quickly. She bundles her new attire under a towel and places her toiletries on top. Then, she heads over to their room’s balcony, taking the box she’d specified reservation to hide behind some potted plants. The box’s contents reveal all the items necessary for planning out her big night with the brunette, from simple decorations to spruce up the place, to a few snacks she knew were her favorite, these she’d introduced to her at Bright Moon after spending so long eating what The Horde offered to her.

When she hears the door of the bathroom open, she leaves the balcony, shuts the sliding door, and covers up her deeds by dragging the curtains over it. She tops it all off by placing her travel bag in the middle, as if to create an obstacle for Catra, were she curious enough to wander the room all on her own.

“Your turn,” Catra says, standing by the door frame. Her short hair’s tucked back, though it changes to a messier style the moment she dries it off with a towel. The rest of her hair remains in a similar state.

Adora smiles, holding back a giggle as she nods, picks up her toiletries, and heads off to the bathroom.

If there was one thing she found adorable, it was seeing Catra after each shower or rainy day. She looked as fuzzy as a regular animal did, and she could only ever stop smiling at that comparison when her girlfriend was done brushing her hair back into shape.

When she closes the door, she finally lets that laugh out, though she still covers it up with a hand over her mouth, reminding herself over how thin the walls are.

She lays out her dress and the rest of the items accompanying it on the drying rack set close to the sink. Her eyes scan the dress, taking a good look at it one final time. She’d spent hours trying to find the best clothes for her outing, not only for the sake of the event, but for herself, too. Now that matters were finally more at peace, she wanted to show it not only through her daily lifestyle with all those around her, but with her girlfriend, also. That outfit was just right for the occasion, with colors made to stand out from the dark blues reflected on the ocean surrounding them, but muted enough to match with her style. Perhaps her She-Ra form was by all means one of the most vibrant versions of herself, but what she wanted most now was to mellow down, relax, and spend more time with her loved ones.

The further she thinks about the topic, the more she notices Catra's changed, too. If she was expressive with her before things grew tense and the hazardous rivalry that formed between them, she was much more cuddly and energetic with her compared to before.

Adora smiles at that thought and hurries up, wanting to finish showering and making preparations to go cuddle with her girlfriend.

Coming Out

When Adora leaves the bathroom, she notices Catra sitting in the middle of their bed, gaze lost in the vastness of the ocean. Her eyes are zoomed in on the scenery and she focuses on every change she sees, from a school of colourful fish swimming by, to the octopus slowly making its way around the sea floor. There's a few sponges and all kinds of algae decorating the rocks around, and a few seahorses standing idly by. She loses herself more in how her girlfriend observes every little thing surrounding her, starting with caution and ending in calm when she realizes she's safe and sound. Her ears are in a constant up and down movement while her tail wags in a careful pace, claws grabbing loosely onto the fabric under her.

She smiles and looks away, staring at the ocean again. For a moment, she grows a bit worried this might be too much for Catra, yet she eases in when she sees a turtle swimming nearby and hears her gasp in response to its arrival. She glances back at her to see her pupils have grown and her grip on the bed sheets tighten.

"Liking the view so far?" she asks, making Catra face her side.

Almost abrupt, the latter changes her expression from awe to shock.

She eyes Adora from top to bottom and a hint of pink stains her cheeks, face regaining an expression similar to the one she carried while staring at the ocean. "It's…" Catra trails off, looking away as she brings a hand to the back of her neck, rubbing her sheepishness away. "...It's pretty nice." Then, she faces back at her, a wider smile reaching her face. "You're looking pretty good, too." She winks, blush fading as a more daring look sparks in her eyes. "What's the occasion?"

Though the brunette has taken just as much effort into dressing up, Adora still plays along. She climbs in bed with her and leans forward, planting a kiss on her nose. “I think you already know,” she says, holding back a laugh. Even though she notices how Catra’s ears are perked up again, she doesn’t mention it and instead brings her face lower and closer to hers, almost brushing with her lips as she waits for her approval.

Catra kisses back, deepening the kiss by holding onto the back of her head. Her fingers tangle with her hair as she brings her even closer, distance almost nonexistent. When it ends, she keeps her hold on her, saying, “I noticed the box.” She grins, cupping her cheek. “Wasn’t this day supposed to be for you?” she asks, fingers grazing with her skin.

Adora scoots away and grabs both of her arms, smiling as she replies with, “But it can still be enjoyable for the both of us,” and completing her words with another kiss to her lips, quicker this time. “Want to help me set things up now that you figured me out?”

Her girlfriend laughs. “Sure.” She nods. “Let’s go.”

She’s the first one to get out of bed, offering her hand out to Adora when she’s done. She brings her in for a hug as soon as she grabs it, mischief flickering in her eyes.

“Hold on tight,” Catra warns, letting go and grabbing her waist.

In an instant, Adora’s swooped off the floor and twirled up in the sky, almost effortlessly with how much muscle her girlfriend managed to build along the years, nearly close enough to match with her own physical strength.

They both burst into a fit of giggles the moment Catra loses her balance. She prevents any possible injuries by nulling the force of the impact against the bed, and a less worrying ‘thump’ accompanies their fall.

The Movies

As if today couldn't be more breathtaking for the both of them, Adora one-ups Catra's surprise by setting up a mini movie theater out in the balcony. It features a calm and sweet-toothed movie about two aliens falling in love; a cliche, forbidden love trope about them being from opposing planets. In contrast to most conflicts though, this one lasts about twenty minutes into the movie, and the other seventy minutes are pure, feel-good moments between the two women. It's about, if not as corny as it sounds. The serious moments it attempts to perform fall short, ending in silliness every time.

With only five minutes left of the movie, the pair begin to doze off, first Adora, and later Catra, the latter who's still too occupied eating snacks to let sleep win her over yet. She munches as quietly as the crunchiness of the chips allows her to and proceeds to pick a less loud food option when she's done with it: a muffin with an alluringly sweet scent to it. She compares that aroma with one she'd whiffed off Adora whenever she went to the kitchen. That makes her steal a quick look at her, mind wondering if, perhaps, the reason why she took so long when it was her turn to cook was due to her trying to bake sweets in secret. The muffin in her hold smells far too similar to Adora's last attempt, and it urges her to take a bite and identify the ingredients in it. Even if it was silly, she could try figuring out if any of those items were found in the pantry of their home.

Vanilla and almonds. Those are the first two tastes she manages to pick off the first bite. She thinks back to the not-so distant past and stumbles upon the memory of Adora working in the garden for hours on end, planting seeds and saplings that were unknown to Catra. Again, she wonders if this is another one of Adora's attempts at surprising her, or if she simply didn't want to let her new hobby be known. Catra takes another bite and catches the hint of another flavor, fruity yet subtle. Then, she faces to her girlfriend's side and smiles wide, warmed by the thought of her practicing so much for something so trifling, not in

the sense of what it was, but for how much Adora seemed to want to keep that a secret by masking these off with the rest of the store-bought snacks she'd brought along. She hadn't once mentioned her baking hobby just as she hadn't mentioned the muffin was made by her, yet Catra has a solid guess as to why that could be.

She kisses her cheek, murmuring "You're such a dork," right as she pulls back. "I wonder how many times you tried that 'til you got it right." Her hand strokes her cheek while her smile grows, fondness overcoming the look in her eyes. "Tell me next time, alright? I'd like to try new things with you, too." She takes her hand back and widens her eyes when she sees Adora toss and turn in her seat, the blanket over her beginning to slip off her body.

Catra acts fast, pulling the sheets back up as she adds, "Were you listening to me?"

She waits for an answer, smile reappearing when she sees Adora turn, breathe deep, and nod, tucking herself into a corner of her seat as she dozes off back to sleep.

"You're the biggest dork here, though," Adora counters. The trace of a smile shows through, most of it overcome by sleep. "Wanting to book a stay here for my sake…" Her last words are murmured as she falls back to sleep. "...Thank you," is the last thing Catra can hear her say when she dozes off completely. She lets her head rest against her shoulder and enjoys the soft, placid warmth of her presence so close to hers.

Catra doesn't bother getting up to turn off the movie and lets it be replayed as she moves closer to Adora's side. She hugs her close and tight, allowing herself to fall asleep in the comfort of her arms.

"...And thank you, too," she whispers, drifting off to sleep.

Fairytale

Two months have passed by since their stay at the underwater hotel. Catra's hair has grown longer since then, and Adora's has gained some volume along the way, creating an image not too far from what her dreams showed to her since the day peace was achieved. The two of them have begun taking college lessons to seek other opportunities aside from protecting Bright Moon and its people. They've set aside extra time to train as they usually did, too, all to avoid falling behind in their combat skills while they strengthened their textbook knowledge in the process.

"Did you manage to solve this one?" Adora asks, holding the notebook up in the air as she rolls over to Catra's side. Her girlfriend giggles when being bumped into and pushes her back, feigning to be bothered by her presence and her question. She grins and nods for her to show her the exercise she's having trouble with. "'It's... this one," the blonde adds, pointing at a mathematical formula fitting for the blueprints for one of Bow's creations. "Did you figure it out? I'm kind of stuck here."

Catra furrows her brow and takes the notebook from her hands, squinting at the numbers as she frowns and shakes her head. "I skipped this one." Her eyes wander over to the textbook, a few marks and scribbles already filling up its pages. "...And I might've spent an hour trying to solve it, too."

The two share a laugh and set their notes aside, facing each other as they say, *"Should we ask for help?"*, in unison.

They then share a smile and continue to face each other, tentative silence falling on them.

"What about Entrapta?" Adora suggests, tapping a pencil against her chin.

Catra hums as she gives the suggestion some thought, shaking her head afterwards. "Maybe she knows all about this,

but I doubt we can get a simple explanation from her. Asking Bow would be better."

Adora pokes at her waist with her index finger and sticks her tongue out at her, teasing the brunette. “But doesn't she give college classes herself now?” She grins. “I’m starting to think we’re both just too slow in anything that has to do with sitting still for more than five seconds.”

Catra laughs, replying with, “Old habits die hard." She shrugs. "It feels weird not having training as our main priority.”

"Weird?" The blonde fakes shock, enhancing it with a gasp. “This's more like a fairytale!” All too sudden, humor falls from her voice as it breaks, tears showing up on the edges of her eyes. “It’s… It’s still hard to believe all this is real. And… And that we have the leisure to relax like this, too. I know it's wrong, b- but I still can’t help feeling guilty whenever I take the time to do anything else aside from training and watching over this place.”

To counter the sudden flood happening on her girlfriend’s face, Catra tugs her along for a hug, setting all textbooks and notes aside as she squeezes her tight. She presses Adora close to her chest, letting her stay there until she recovers some more.

She doesn’t say anything in response, part of her fears matching with her own.

Even so, she hugs her tight and doesn’t let go, whispering words of comfort until Adora achieves a state of calm. “We’ll be alright,” Catra mutters, passing her fingers through her hair and unsnapping her ponytail along the way. “And if anything happens, we’re not alone, and we’ll all make sure to fight for what we have; for… for what we’ve gained through the years.”

Catra feels Adora nod against her, followed by her hands holding her waist. “I love you.” She lifts her gaze away from her chest and meets with her eyes, tears still present in hers.

"I love you, too," Catra replies. She closes her eyes and kisses her lips, an action quick enough to go unnoticed were Adora to have hers the same way.

She kisses back, closing her eyes this time as she deepens it, her turn to hug now.

Graveyard Shift

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With how much effort had been put into maintaining Bright Moon at peace, it wasn't shocking for Adora to be assigned late night guard duties every once in a while. And while it wasn't inherently necessary with how many people were around and how much had been done to improve the security systems set up, she still tried her best to do a good job, be it by helping its people with simpler chores or making her rounds about the streets, until the sun finally came by.

The only stuff that bothered her were cold nights like today's. Though it was a trifling matter nonetheless, the cold numbed her skin and made her think back on what, or rather *who* waited for her at home. Catra would be sleeping right now, no doubt; but the blonde could at least have someone to cuddle and warm herself with.

She smiles at that, imagining the sound of her purring, until it isn't her imagination anymore.

In an instant, she turns around to verify she's not hearing things and comes across a more logical explanation than that of her girlfriend being up at three in the morning: a dark grey cat making his way to her side. The little one's caught his head in a box, yet he attempts to free himself by hitting at Adora's leg, meowing and purring for help. She lets out a laugh and smiles down at the feline; then, she crouches and reaches out for the box, being careful not to startle him away.

The cat hisses a few times as she tries to get his head unstuck, yet that all results in failure and him running off.

"Wait!" she shouts, to no avail.

It's already too late by the time she calls out for him. She runs to where he zoomed past and comes across nothing else but empty streets and the occasional passerby either taking a walk or sitting by a bench. There's not much else she can do besides either continue looking or giving up, but neither of those options are needed when she hears the same, familiar purring nearby. Based on the sound, the cat's happier now, so she tries her best to search for him and ends up coming across an unusual sight: her girlfriend up at three in the morning, but sitting on a bench and with a cat resting on her lap.

The brunette looks to her side first and the cat soon follows; the latter hisses at Adora while the former smiles, greeting her with her free hand.

"Busy shift tonight?" she teases, grinning.

Adora returns that expression and places a hand on her hip, replying with, "Did you see me?"

Catra nods and gestures with her gaze for the blonde to join her side, scooting herself and the cat away to leave more space for her. "If it helps, you have to be more careful around animals when they're struck like that," she says, petting the cat's head and watching as he yawns. He stretches his body and nuzzles up to Catra, chest rising and falling at a calm, steady pace. "They're already scared enough with what's going on, so you have to take it *real* slow if you want to help them out."

She takes the cat with both hands and offers him out to Adora. "Want to pet him now?"

There's a moment of reluctance before the blonde can reply. Eventually, she nods and reaches a hand out for the cat, flinching when he moves so much as an inch. He doesn't do anything when her hand lands on the top of his head, bringing a wave of relief to her body, one she lets out in the shape of a soft breath.

"He's cute," Adora comments, smiling.

Catra smiles back and sets the cat back down on her lap. Then, she shifts closer to Adora and holds her cheek, tugging at her face for her gaze to meet with her own. When it does, her smile grows and she prepares herself to say the corniest line ever known.

"Just like you."

To counter its blow, she gives her a quick kiss and places a hand back on the cat's head, petting him to emphasize her point.

"...But you're less fluffy and *way* better to cuddle with."

Chapter End Notes

Updates will be twice a week on Saturdays and Sundays from here on out!

Coffee Shop

With how much word Bright Moon received, how many people lived there, and how many visits were made every day, it's no surprise new stores have begun to show up. Similar to how she'd spent weeks planning for a trip to the underwater hotel, Catra was now busy setting things up to spend her next day off there. Her next date would be at the new shopping center, but before that, she needed to visit it on her own first and later plan out from there. Though it was no doubt strange for her to prepare so much for something so mundane, she felt more at ease with a plan in mind, even for the simplest things there were.

It's her third and what she hopes is her last day of preparing. She already knows what the center looks like and has her first destination in mind: a coffee shop owned by Perfuma and Scorpia. Not only was it a calm and cozy place to start their date, but having familiar faces around made her feel less nervous about it.

A year's passed since she started living with Adora, and yet she still felt butterflies whenever she planned out dates with her.

Catra leaves hand-in-hand with Adora by her side only after she's revised her plan one more time.

"Ready to go?" Adora asks, noticing her uncertainty.

The one in question nods, though she grips her hand and waits for her to make the first move. When she does, she faces her girlfriend and takes a better look at the outfit she's wearing today: a sundress with colours similar to the sunset's. There's a flower clip decorating her hair and keeping her bangs out of the way, tempting Catra to jump at her and take the accessory off of her, just to see what her bangs looked like now that they were longer. She still had her famous hair poof, but it was growing out more, and she wondered if Adora would ever let her bangs loose, as she often did with the rest of her hair.

"Not that I mind you staring, but…" Adora speaks up and a grin shows on her face. "We're already here."

Catra's eyes widen and she can only respond by looking forward, the scent of coffee leading the way. "...*How?*" she asks. "We were at our place just a minute ago!"

"It's fine, y'know?" The blonde teases her further with a wink. "I don't blame you for being so distracted by me."

Catra scoffs and feigns anger by knitting her eyebrows, letting Adora's hand go, and crossing her arms. "I wasn't distracted." She meets her eyes and tries to contain her smile. "*You* distracted me. It's different."

Adora shrugs. "Same thing, different words."

Before the two can begin their usual banter, from the coffee shop exit both owners of the establishment, sweet and tangy scents wafting out behind them. Perfuma has two cups of coffee in her hands while Scorpia carries a tray full of pastries. The two of them smile and greet them in. "We've been waiting for you," the former of the two says, nudging at the one next to her. "Scorpia's been waiting all day to show you the new sweets she baked!"

The pair enter and reach out for the food offered to them, though the sweets almost end up on the floor with how excited Scorpia is and how difficult it is for her to keep the tray balanced in her hands. Even so, she manages to recover from her slip just in time and guides them over to the table Perfuma sets out for them.

"We'll be out of your tail in a minute," Scorpia says, taking a seat. "But first, try those out and tell us what you think!"

With the warmth of the shop, the amiability of her company, and the sight of Adora sitting nearby, Catra smiles bright and eases into the moment. She does as her friend says: takes a pastry first and brings it to her mouth, eyes closed as she

readies herself to give her thoughts on it. A sweet taste spreads on her mouth, amplifying when she hears Adora exclaim a compliment about its taste.

When she opens her eyes and looks to her side, she sees the tray has already lost a few more pastries, and evidence of where they went are present on her girlfriend's cheeks.

Feeling it's a good moment to fulfill a staple for most romance novels, Catra leans in, smiles, and reaches out for her, kissing the cookie crumbs off her face.

Sleepover

One thing had led to the other, and now the pair were staying at Perfuma's for the night. Scorpia's present, too, making it a double date, even if the latter of the two was a bit oblivious about it. Perfuma sets out another tray of tea for everyone, though it's a different flavour now. There's the scent of chamomile, lemon, and mint wafting through the air, paired up with the smell of more pastries still waiting their time at the oven.

"So," Scorpia says, smiling wide. "How about we start planning a trip? It's almost summer soon!"

The one who seemed the most oblivious out of all turns out to be the one responsible for having set up the double date. Perfuma smiles at her and brings out a computer from the bookshelf nearby. She sets it down on the table and tells everyone to gather closer, smile turning softer when Scorpia sits next to her and lets her rest against her while she turns the device on.

"Do you prefer the mountains or the beach?" Perfuma asks, facing Catra first before looking at Adora. "Feel free to choose whatever's more comfortable with you. Scorpia and I are fine with both!" She smiles at them, bringing forth some encouragement as she waits for their reply.

Adora doesn't need to stare at Catra to know she's already tense. Their stay at the underwater hotel had turned out a success, but her girlfriend needed plenty of time and support to overcome part of her fears. She didn't want to impose on her again, and even less knowing this was an outing with other people. Having more company around would be fun, but not when one of them was still in the process of battling her fears.

"What do you think?" she asks, words directed at Catra. She meets face-to-face with her and smiles. Then, she reaches out for her hand and holds it close. "I'm good with both, too."

Catra's ears droop and a frown shows up on her face. Her tail swooshes around and her hand lets go of Adora's when she says, "...The mountains."

Nobody present questions further over her decision and instead nod along to it. Adora faces Perfuma and shares a look with her, giving a silent agreement for the final decision to be made.

Even if she'd chosen the mountains, Adora was aware of which place Perfuma was referring to, and she knew it was best to pick out a place that wouldn't be too overcome by lakes or ponds. Even humidity made Catra uneasy, but while she adjusted, it was best to take things step-by-step rather than throwing her headfirst into it.

It marks past midnight by the time the trip is settled out. All the pastries and tea are gone, and the computer's been left to charge while Scorpia goes to set up a movie for everyone to watch. Perfuma, on the other hand, has some savoury snacks readied by the kitchen, an offer she'd made and one that had been taken by everyone in agreement to them needing something salty to contrast with the tangy taste of the tea and the sweetness of the pastries.

By the time the movie's already set up, though, Catra's already fallen asleep. She rests her head on Adora's lap and mutters unintelligible words under her breath. It continues that way until Perfuma and Scorpia sit down nearby. From there on, Adora can make out some of the words, hearing her girlfriend still debating in her mind if she should've chosen the beach instead.

The other pair present smile and hold back giggles at the scenario. Adora, meanwhile, sets a hand down on Catra's scalp

and passes her fingers through her hair, bringing her back into a deep sleep.

"Want me to take her to the guest bedroom?" Scorpia asks, still smiling at the sight.

Adora nods and returns her smile, letting go of Catra when she's sure she won't stir in her sleep again.

Amusement Park

For their next trip before the big double date, Adora's chosen an amusement park. With how much there's to explore and sightsee, she figures it would be useful to burn some energy through taking a few coasters, and perhaps even flex her combat abilities in sillier situations, like that of winning herself a big cat plushie in a ring tossing game and teasing her girlfriend over how much they looked alike.

The weather turns those expectations around with a sudden and relentless rainfall. Thunder rumbles from a distance and she's obliged to comply. She sighs and sets the clothes she picked out back in the closet. Then, she looks for the tickets and stares at them for a while. It would be too late to go when the rain stopped judging by how grey and dull the sky looks, so she admits her defeat and saves those plans and the admissions for another day; hopefully, not too late ahead, though. She wanted to help Catra unwind a bit more by picking out something thrilling before their big and long-awaited vacation day.

Though preparations had started with only the idea of Perfuma and Scorpia joining in, they stretched it out to a bigger plan, one that eventually developed in all four of them inviting other friends who were couples and splitting the costs to afford a bigger vacationing space.

Just as Adora's mind drifts off to that day, a rain coat's thrown at her face. She takes it off, looks down at it, and later up to see Catra standing by the door, wearing one herself, albeit red unlike her bright orange one. Similar to all other hoodied outfits she wore, the rain coat has additional pockets made for her ears. It was something many of her friends often teased her for, yet Adora was taking to other ways of doing that. Whenever she could, she would sneak a kiss or two on the back of Catra's ears and run off before she could process what was going on.

"Let's go to the garden," her girlfriend offers. "We should check to see if the new plants aren't getting drowned, and we can take a walk along the way, too."

Adora smiles at her and replies with, "So you planted new ones?"

"A new flower Perfuma showed me," she elaborates, returning her smile. "Don't ask her which, though. I'm gonna keep it a surprise for you until it blooms."

Feeling it's an adequate time to tease her now, Adora manages to sneak a quick kiss on her left ear and later another on her right one. She tries to walk faster afterwards to avoid being caught, yet Catra grabs her wrist and twirls her back to her side, leaving Adora face-to-face with her. "You really thought I hadn't noticed this before?" Her words are playful despite the subtle challenge in them, and her smile changes for a sly, goofy grin. "Guess now it's *my* turn, then."

Adora's vain attempt at escaping only results in Catra hugging her tighter. She keeps her trapped in her arms and kisses her right ear lobe, biting it after. "Hey!" the blonde protests, and giggles contradict her. Her few giggles then turn to full-on laughter as the brunette tickles her sides, making her give up and lay limp in her arms. She fakes to be faint and slumps against Catra's chest, keeping an eye open to see her expression.

"That won't work on me, Adora," Catra says, lifting her up bridal style.

She then carries her off back to her room and throws her in bed.

"So either you stop pretending and admit you've been doing that, or I'll have to get the truth out of you through a tickle war."

Adora continues to pretend and soon regrets it when Catra kisses her left ear lobe next, a feeling ticklish enough for her to

swat her away with her hands. “I… I thought you said it's a tickle war?” she asks, opening her eyes to meet with Catra’s.

"Maybe I did. But I can do both just fine, mind you,” she retorts, winking at her.

Parade

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It takes three more days to finally find one where they're both free from work and the weather isn't a factor of concern. It's bright and windy out; the few clouds present and the lack of shade they bring's contrasted by the cool breeze. Catra would be coming home soon, while Adora's been free since three hours ago. During that time, she's changed her outfit twice, paced around the house a few times, and practiced asking her girlfriend over that special something in the mirror.

From her night stand's bottom drawer, Adora retrieves an engagement ring. She stares at it with blank eyes for a while, mind lost and conflicted as to how she could bring the subject up with Catra. Along the years, she'd watched plenty of corny romcoms, telenovelas, and dramas just to find the perfect idea for a proposal. Despite all that preparation, however, she doesn't have a set idea in mind yet. She wanted to make it a surprise, but at the same time, she wanted to keep it private and simple, without too many people staring and waiting to see what would happen.

Her thoughts are interrupted by the sound of a marching band. It's distant, but Adora can still hear the cheery melody from where she stands at. It's then when her long-awaited idea arrives, almost like an epiphany. She pockets the ring, closes the drawer, and rushes out of the room when she hears the melody turn louder. The band was approaching, and based on the route it seemed to be taking, measured by how distant it sounded at first, it was making its way all around Bright Moon. Whether it was a planned or spontaneous event she wasn't quite aware of, though she still thanked whatever guarding angel watched over her to grant her an idea.

She could try inviting Catra to the park's concert and sneak the ring in her hands when she wasn't paying attention. She could try hiding it in a plushie prize's ear, or she could try hiding it while they snuggled at the ferris wheel together. She could-

Her eyes are covered up by fuzzy hands and sharp nails, the latter trying to be gentle to avoid hurting her. "Guess who," Catra says, faking a deeper voice.

Adora laughs and pushes her away, taking her girlfriend's wrists and keeping her hold on them as she turns her around. Her hold on her stays strong and she makes her stay in place, something that lasts until she looks at her own hands and sees a ring's been slipped on her finger. Before she can even say anything, Catra grins, tugs her close, and locks her arms around her back. "I saw you take out that ring plenty of times before, but I wasn't sure by then if it was meant for me." She chuckles and lays a kiss right on Adora's nose. "...But then I noticed you got all nervous the closer we got to that trip next week, and you kinda just spoiled the surprise you were trying to hide from me."

Adora can feel her cheeks burn at the reveal, yet she tries to confirm she'd heard right by asking, "Was I *that* obvious?" Her quizzical frown changes for an amused smile, one she attempts to cover up by looking away from Catra's eyes. "I… I just wanted to practice the proposal."

Her girlfriend snickers at that and almost seems to blush based on the faint pink on her cheeks. "In the end, you made it before you were even aware of it." Her attention then moves on to the ring she'd slipped on Adora's finger. The wearer stares at it for a while, and it's at that moment Catra figures more context could be given. "This's my response to your proposal, by the way." She takes Adora's hands and stretches up a little to match with her height. She bumps her forehead against hers, closes her eyes, and gives her a quick kiss on the lips, muttering an *"I do, Adora,"* right before pulling away and taking a step back.

Now face-to-face with each other, the two remain silent and smile, maintaining fond and teary gazes as they lack words to express themselves with. The marching band turns louder the longer they wait, and when they hear the cymbals ring just a little too jarring for their ears, they break the silence of the moment to go stare at what's happening outside.

When Adora does, she reacts almost on instinct. Her mouth lets out a gasp and her hand tries to cover it up. Her eyes, on the other hand, become more teary than they already were and she feels the urge to hug Catra tight.

With its *'Congratulations!'* banner and the large picture of her and Catra holding hands together, the band was no doubt meant for them two.

Catra had one-upped her two times without knowing, both in her learning about her plans for proposing and letting Bright Moon know over the news.

Chapter End Notes

Forgot I had to post a new chapter yesterday, so there's double update today. 🙈

Dance

The two celebrate taking another big step through turning on some music and taking each other around for a dance. It starts out slow and easy, with a waltz similar to those played at the Princess Prom. Though as time passes, fast and energetic tunes begin playing, urging the both of them to let our their pent up excitement through different forms of dance, from upbeat salsa to poorly improvised tango, to other types they could barely even give a name to.

Another catchy song plays just as they're thinking of calling it off for the day, and it's after that one ends that they agree on turning off the radio, having a drink to recover, and throwing themselves on the couch to rest. Adora goes for the remote while Catra fluffs up the cushions, readying up some space for her to cuddle with Adora in. Her heart's racing, though she's not sure how much of it's due to the reminder she was now engaged and how much of it was due to the fact they'd been dancing for a full hour. Dancing was, in a way, a masked and funner form of exercise, so it's no doubt over where part of her exhaustion comes from. She breathes in and out in search for some calm as she rests her back against the cushions, yawns, and stretches her arms out.

When she notices Adora hasn't joined her yet, she looks before her to see her girlfriend still seems to be having trouble finding a channel to watch, as her face remains glued to the television and she still has the remote pointing straight at it. "Do you… Do you want to dance for our wedding day?" she asks, still facing the television as she continues to pass by channels, barely giving any of them enough time to utter a word in context and much less reveal what the broadcast is about.

Catra sits up straighter at the sound of that question. She faces Adora's back with a frown, confusion mostly seen in it and her voice as she says, "Of course I do. Why do you ask?"

She hears Adora sigh and sees her set the control down. She's left it on a performance arts channel, though she doesn't bother to stare at the television screen anymore. Rather, Adora faces her lap and refuses to make eye contact with anything else around her. "I don't know why, but..." A huff leaves her mouth and she covers her face with her hands, still giving her back to Catra. "Even though it's been lots of years already, I… I got reminded of that time at the Princess Prom." Finally, she turns around and faces Catra with a weak and strained smile. "It worried me for a bit, but then I also felt better knowing we've come this far. So I guess I'm just not sure how to interpret those feelings, and if they're good or not."

Catra scoots closer to her girlfriend's side and hugs her from behind. She rests her chin on her shoulder and lets her ease into the embrace before saying, "If you're asking me, then I think it's normal." Her hold on her loosens for a moment, until she carries on with, "That waltz we did reminded me of that day, too, but after that, it… It made me feel better about ourselves and where we are now."

She lays back against the cushions again when Adora snuggles up next to her. They both stay quiet for a moment, enjoying each other's company until Catra adds, "...So even if it's normal or not, we've identified what's bothering us, and now we can work on it together, and I'd say that's pretty good all on its own." She kisses Adora's cheek at the sight of her smiling and brings her closer against her. "But what do you think, though?"

There's a short period of silence as she waits for her to find her answer. "I think so, too." Adora's smile grows and she returns Catra's kiss with a quicker one on the lips. "Thank you for listening."

Mutual Support

"C'mon," Adora shouts, looking up to wave at Catra. "Jump," she adds, stretching her arms out. "I'll catch you!"

Catra's ears hide away as she looks down at the pool waiting right below her feet. Only some distance and the diving board are what keep her from touching the water, though when the wind hits, she feels as if there's nothing under her. She stumbles and closes her eyes in sheer instinct as she begins to fall. No scream leaves her mouth and instead, both her fur and tail spike. She expects to hit the water and feel her body sting in response to her ungraceful dive, though she's caught by Adora…

...And *then* they both fall.

Having stumbled so abruptly, her girlfriend wasn't given the chance to prepare for the sudden drop of weight. Catra, on the other hand, wasn't anticipating such a fall and had frozen in fear for the entire time it lasted. While it was said cats and other felines often stood upright after a fall, she was part human and didn't want to believe those sayings she often heard, not because she refused to accept she was part feline and that some of these were true, but because it was that way that Netossa had found out over one of her sillier weaknesses.

"Are you okay?" Adora asks, swimming back to her side. Though her hair sticks out every which way and her breaths are still ragged from the event, she's recovered enough to hold Catra and prevent her from sinking further in the pool. "Does it hurt anywhere?" she asks, holding her face in her hands, cheeks being squished as her gaze furrows and looks her up and down in concern. "It... It didn't sting, did it?"

Catra smiles and shakes her head, bursting out a laugh when hearing her voice's muffled up by Adora's hands still squishing her cheeks. "I'm okay," she says, breaking away from

her hold. "But what about you? You were the one who broke the fall for me."

"...I'm-"

The brunette raises an eyebrow as she waits for her girlfriend to reply. Knowing how eager she was to teach her how to break free from her fears, Catra was more than certain Adora would try to cover up the damage just so they could spend some more time working on that together. To counter that possibility, she sighs, smiles, and finally, takes her shoulders to bring her close. She inspects her and sees a few reddish marks already beginning to show on the parts her full-body swimsuit doesn't manage to cover up; her legs, mostly. The rest of her seems okay on a first glance, though when she decides to squeeze at her arms covered up by long sleeves, the blonde lets out a sharp hiss and takes a step back, a bit slowed down due to the water.

"You're hurt," Catra points out, frowning at the observation. "Let's take you back."

"I'm fine-"

"No, you're not."

Her frown turns to a glare as she waits to see if Adora will continue to deny it.

Thankfully, she smiles and lets out what Catra assumes is a sigh in surrender. "I knew you'd figured me out," she says, giving in with a faint smile. Then, she meets with her eyes and laughs, smile changing for a grin. "Thanks." There's a moment of reluctance present in her, one where Catra sees a subtle blush on her cheeks. "Think you could carry me off, then? My legs feel a little shaky."

Barely needing that excuse to agree with her, Catra nods and stands up straight in the water.

The two walk off to dryer land, where she finally takes action, sweeping Adora in her arms and kissing her cheek.

"Let's get you patched up," she says, walking off. "Hold on tight, Adora... And maybe hug me, if you want, too."

Adora giggles and buries her face against her shoulder. "Will do," she replies, arms locking around Catra's neck.

Confession

"I'm grateful to have you."

Adora turns back around at the sound of such a sudden sentence.

Catra's sitting up straight, posture as firm as a wall as her gaze meets with the blonde's. Her ears twitch as she waits, so Adora smiles, waiting a little longer for her girlfriend to blush and exclaim, "S- Say something!" Her stutter is just as cute as her face, pink present on her cheeks. "Don't just stare at me like that, you dork!"

"And what am I supposed to say?" Adora asks, confidence present in her voice -- a little more, and it would *definitely* pass off as cocky. She places her hands on her hips and looks at Catra with a grin, smugness made more than prominent through it. "You caught me off guard with how sweet that was." She chuckles at the sight of Catra taking the nearest pillow available and using it to cover her face away from her eyes. "But…" Adora sighs and walks back to her side. Then, she sits next to her in bed and places a hand on her head. "Thank you -- I mean it."

Catra refuses to let go of the pillow still pushed against her face, so she resorts to caressing her ears with both hands, until she drives out a purr and a shudder from her. "H- Hey!" Her protest is weak, and it soon falls flat as she leans her head against one of Adora's hands, an indirect way of telling her to focus more on that ear instead. "...And I meant what I said, too," she says, words muttered. "I feel like I haven't shown that enough lately."

"I'd say the opposite," Adora remarks, smile brightening when Catra finally makes eye contact with her. Their gazes focus on each other, until she continues with, "So remember that next time you're not too sure of yourself, alright? It's great to be with you like this."

A smile manages to show up on Catra's face despite how pink her cheeks still are. Her ears tense as she looks away for a second, lower lip bitten on in that quick moment. She seems lost in thought, so Adora leaves her be for a while.

"...Wanna go outside?" the brunette offers, snapping out of her trance. "As comfy as this room is, we're still on vacation, and I'm far from sleepy."

Adora nods and stands up, stretching afterwards. "Thought you'd never ask," she says, meeting Catra's eyes again. "I was thinking about that too, but then I also wanted to stay here and cuddle with you."

Her girlfriend's ears twitch once more, and her gaze carries itself elsewhere to avoid Adora's face. "Now's your turn to catch me off guard, huh?"

"I'm *serious*, Catra."

Catra snickers and stands up, nudging Adora's hip with her elbow once she's close enough. "I know." Her smile grows. "But why not both? First, we go out. And then we can cuddle for the rest of the night."

"Sounds good," Adora replies, a blush of her own showing through.

"Let's go," she then adds, taking Catra's hand and tugging for her to follow along. "I've got something I want to show you!"

Proposal

Adora knew this would be coming soon, but she sure didn't anticipate it happening in the middle of their vacation.

She's more than happy with Catra's choice to have made it in private by the hotel room's backyard, as not only did it prevent any audiences from creating any unnecessary expectations and sending them at her, but it also allowed for her to reply with, "I… I do, Catra, but I think we need more time. It... It's just so sudden and-"

Her girlfriend smiles and puts an end to her rambling by closing the box and pocketing it away back where it was. She gets up from her kneeling position and smiles, not an ounce of uncertainty visible in her actions. She doesn't seem sad, disappointed, and much less angry. In contrast, her eyes are warm and her smile is genuine as she pecks Adora on the lips, calming her down. "Don't sweat it," she says, words hush as a gentler expression lands on her face. "Of course we can wait, silly! It's-"

Adora witnesses Catra's eyes dilate and her mouth fall open once she pulls a reverse card on her. It's now her turn to get down on one knee and for the one being proposed now to stay frozen, tail and ears just as denoting of her shock as the rest of her face is. "I was planning to propose to you, too, but... It looks like you beat me to it, huh?" she says, chuckling after. "...Does this mean we're both fiancées now?"

Trying not to grin is a complex feat for the blonde as she waits for a reply. Her knelt leg and her extended arm turn numb as she waits, though that's soon forgotten when Catra replies with, "Y- Yes." Her voice is hardly a whisper and could most likely pass off as the wind, but it's still raw with honesty, vulnerability shown through every factor.

Still, Catra compliments her answer by taking out her fiancée's ring and slipping it on for her. Adora does the same for her, though she takes longer in doing so. Her movements are slow and teasing, invoking the faintest blush on Catra's cheeks when she chooses to kiss her hand like a knight would with a princess in those typical fairy tales they had both been into reading as of recent.

Then, she swoops the brunette in her arms, winks, and carries her off back to their shared hotel room, where she sets her down by the living room.

"Stay here," she says, leaving her be by the couch. Catra doesn't budge an inch and much less does she think of sitting down, still too flustered by the events at their backyard for her to snap out of it. "I need to give you something."

Catra's left to wait with shaky legs and a burning face, both she fails in controlling.

It only worsens when Adora returns, carrying what has to be one of the top grand things she's gifted Catra ever since they became girlfriends. A box of candies lay on her hand, clearly made by the blonde herself judging by how there's no company logo, name, or nutrition facts printed anywhere on the box. "It's one for each year we've been together -- as both friends and girlfriends," Adora says, giving her the box.

Catra smiles. "Then it's only fair we share them, don't you think so?" she asks, smile growing as she opens the box and inspects its contents. "Wanna eat these outside? The moon's really bright today."

Adora nods, though she doesn't waste time and takes one from the open box, inviting Catra for her to share the candy with her. "Half-and-half," she says, voice muffled by the candy.

She chuckles, yet she soon finds herself drawn in by her, until her lips meet with the sweet and melts -- half in her mouth,

and half in Adora's, so permitting her to meet with her smudged lips next.

The candy's sweetness is doubled as they kiss, as so is her desire to always have Adora safe and nearby. Her sentiments are reciprocated by that same woman, who brings her closer and makes the kiss last longer. They break away seconds after, meeting with each other's gazes with as much warmth and confidence as a bright and sunny day on April, and a hand-made pastry fresh out of the oven.

Wedding

One of Adora's dreams comes true the moment they're declared wife and wife. She repeats the phrase in her head over and over -- even as she kisses Catra and even as they both walk away from the aisle hand-in-hand. The cheers that follow are almost deafening with how loud everyone is, a bit of a peculiar observation to take in based on how tiny the crowd is.

They'd both agreed on making it a small gathering with how nervous they both felt over their big day, and they'd chosen to leave any big celebrations for later on. As a result, they thank everyone and say their farewells as quickly as the vows felt, these seeming to have lasted nothing with how equally anxious they both were. Saying *'I do'* was about as hard as a college admission test, regardless of how they both felt ready for their next step and how much they practiced at home before today. Kissing in front of so many people was harder still, though neither of them can deny the warm feeling that's left behind after having people cheer on for them.

"Ready to take off?" Catra asks, foot already pressing on the brakes as she waits for Adora to get in the car, open front passenger door left waiting for her. A smile encourages her to step inside and look forward to the ride, as so does receiving a kiss on the cheek when she sits down.

Adora buckles up and nods, smiling after. "I'm ready," she says, meeting her eyes. "What about you?"

Catra nods back, a smile of her own showing up as she then pulls her hair back in a ponytail, closes her eyes for a while, and sighs. "I've been thinking about sending everyone a thank-you letter with how helpful they've been." A bashful look overcomes her, and she gives a more reserved smile. "What do you think?"

"Sounds like a plan," she replies, winking at her. "A cute one, too."

Rather than engaging into banter as the pair often did, Catra looks away. A blush dusts her cheeks and she purrs in response to the compliment, making Adora stifle a giggle and drown it out by turning on the radio. They look at each other after that, no more words needed for the driver to take her foot off the breaks and for the passenger to set up the radio to her favourite tunes, heightening the mood of the ride as the car takes off. Open windows send gusts of air in, making them both loosen up more and grin wide as their hair's tousled by the wind's strength.

It's a strong, never ending feeling, even as they stop at various red lights. The sensation stays the same and adrenaline only increases as Catra continues to drive, the three hour-long drive felt like nothing with the company she has next to her. "Want me to drive next?" Adora asks, words audible thanks to a red light. "You should take a break."

Though Catra looks like she's about to reject the offer at first, she gives into it with a slow nod and parks at the emergency lane once the opportunity arrives. They then switch seats, though not before sharing another kiss similar to the one at their wedding ceremony. It's far more exhilarating now, the pressure felt from before now entirely gone and replaced by comfort.

"Thanks, Dora," Catra says, breaking the kiss apart.

Adora smiles and preps the car before continuing with the drive. "Anytime, Applesauce."

Anniversary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Now that Catra's managed to lessen her fear of water, they both agree it's about an adequate time for them to book another stay at that underwater hotel. Though it's been a few years since that day, the two still remember everything like it was yesterday, from the way Adora had carried her then-girlfriend in her arms, to the quiet time they spent watching movies in their hotel room. Even the little details of the room are still imprinted in their minds, these hard to forget with how breathtaking the view from above was.

Their plans to celebrate their one-year go smoothly from start to finish, until they actually make it inside their room.

"What..." Adora's voice falters as she walks in -- breathtaking, but quite unlike the first time she stepped foot into this place. "What *happened* here?" Her eyes widen and her mouth almost gapes as that question leaves her thoughts.

Catra joins her by looking up, following her wife's gaze until she sees just how bleak the water is and how little fish there are swimming around. They hold each other's hands instinctively and share a worried look, further questions difficult to say out loud with how abrupt the change is. What was once a view taken straight out of a fairy tale is now a near apocalyptic landscape. Murky waters stain what used to be a picture-perfect scenery, and the few sea creatures still left around look just as sickly as their environment.

Adora's frown shows and she grips Catra's hand tighter. Another glance at each other's faces gives an answer as to what they should do: contact the most knowledgeable person around

about this subject. Surely, she'd have an answer -- and some authority over the situation, too.

"I'll call," Adora says, changing her frown for a straight line. "Do you think you could ask anyone about this while I'm done?"

Catra nods, firm and confident. "Leave it to me." They meet with each other and share a kiss on the lips. "I'll see you in a bit."

With that agreement settled out between them, Catra hurries out of the room while Adora sits in bed. She can feel nervousness build in her throat, though she tries not to let the situation get to her too much. It was strange to think how the reservations were made without them catching anything out of the ordinary during that process. And it was stranger still to have made it past the parking lot, the lobby, and the elevator -- pretty much, all the way up to the hallway -- only to have the ugly truth revealed to them here.

As she waits for Mermista to pick up, she can only wonder if -- maybe -- things had been too good to be true these days.

Her hands begin to sweat and she starts to grow short of oxygen, sensations that lessen when she takes consistent breaths in and out. She's further calmed down when the door opens, revealing Catra standing behind it. Her wife's with someone who looks like one of the hotel's janitors, though the person waits outside while Catra does the opposite. Her brows furrow in concern and a patient smile shows on her face, empathy made present in the subtle wetness of her eyes. *"You okay?*" she mouths, meeting Adora's eyes.

She smiles back and tries not to jump off the bed when Mermista finally picks up.

"Are you guys doing alright?" she asks, voice sounding muffled from her line. "Aren't you... supposed to be celebrating

your anniversary right now?" Her voice is far from sarcastic as she says that; rather, worry drenches her words -- as if she's formed the worst-case scenario in her head. "Tell me the truth, Adora."

Adora sighs and spares one quick look at Catra before waving at her, smiling again, and gaining some confidence back. She then breathes in sharp, bracing herself through it. Whatever situation was being brushed under the rug, she had Catra by her side -- and friends like Mermista, too. Looming trouble or not, they would get through this.

With that thought in mind, she replies with, "It's not about our anniversary, but…"

She tells Mermista the gist of the situation, making the woman almost scream out a *'What?!'* from how sudden the news is, and despite how much the blonde had tried to ease her into the topic.

"You two wait right there," she says, anger masked by a stern tone. "I'll get there soon."

Chapter End Notes

There will be two more updates next week after this one, and then the story will go on-hold until October, as the last 5 chapters will be redone and made longer!

Acceptance

While Adora and Mermista discuss the situation, Catra stays inside the hotel room, gaze cast at the water as she contemplates the past. The reasonable side of her tells her there's a logical explanation behind it; on the other hand, the more anxious side of her fears karma might be behind this. She starts to think back on all the things she could've done differently, and wonders if the past is beginning to bite back at her now. Breathing in, she tries to find a more balanced mindset and chooses to distract herself by joining her wife and her friend out in the hallway.

"So you think it might be coincidental, then?" she hears Adora say, voice becoming clearer once she opens the door and leaves the room.

"I'd say both could be possible," Mermista replies, crossing her arms. Her face scrunches up and her eyebrows furrow. A sigh leaves her mouth and she tries to hide a frown. "The janitor said the room wasn't like this the last time it was her turn to clean it, so…" She trails off and looks up; her gaze follows a school of fish making their way to the top, searching for the light shining above them. It's an oddity to see the sun shining bright and the water still fresh and clear on this side of the hotel, though it makes more sense when Catra follows the woman's eyes and sees her frown at the cloud of pollution slowly making its way here. "We shouldn't really brush off either of those possibilities. Coincidence or sabotage, we need to act fast if we don't want this to keep on spreading."

Catra’s chest shudders as she huffs. She tries not to let her mind get carried away into the future, yet it's near impossible to do. There's already plenty of scenarios running wild in her mind, going this way and that when she decides to make up different solutions for each one of them. She doesn't want to worry Adora further, and much less on their anniversary, so she stays quiet and

continues to watch by the sidelines while her wife and her friend work with the situation.

"Is there anything I could do to speed the process up a bit more?" she asks, worry fueling her courage to speak up. "O- Or…" Her hands clench and her throat turns dry. "Or any way I could prevent anything big from happening?" Catra's legs shake and she flinches when she feels a few cold tears rush down her face. "I-"

"Of course you can," Mermista says, intervening while Adora approaches her side.

She places a hand against Catra's cheek and smiles at her, made saddened by the teary look in her eyes. "But try not to worry so much about it, alright? We still need to find leads before we go anywhere else with this." Adora rubs her thumb against her cheek and soothes her back into calm; a few tears leave her eyes when she blinks, making Catra step in by wiping one away with a kiss. "Seeing you cry makes me wanna cry, too."

Catra chuckles and brings her closer. "Is that why you cried at least ten times at our wedding?" she asks, grinning.

"Only *three* times, mind you," Adora replies, nudging her waist. "The other seven times were because of how cute everything was." She then fakes anger as she adds. "And you cried at least *three* times yourself, so don't you dare try to wiggle yourself out of this one!"

"I won't," Catra says, letting her tears run free the moment Adora hugs her, tight enough to squeeze all the worry and fear out of her body.

"Good."

Midnight Snacks

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

To counter their worries and the endless, anxious thoughts that follow them, the two stay up and choose to watch whatever shows and commercials the hotel's television services offer them, but not before going out for some snacks to pass what's left of the night eating and talking. It's almost eleven when they both leave their room, and -- by the time they make it back -- it's almost midnight. Adora proceeds to dump everything they've bought on the nearby dresser while Catra stores the drinks away in the fridge. They then sit down in bed and one of them takes the remote, cuddling next to each other when everything's set up.

Ironically enough, the first channel they come across with when turning on the television is a documentary on sea life, directed by none other than Sea Hawk. The mood is far more upbeat and cheery in comparison to their current situation, so the pair agree on switching to the next channel for an alternative. The sound goes from normal to far-too loud for how late it is, urging Catra to fumble for the volume buttons and quiet down the commercial promoting the same place they're both staying in.

An idea pops into Catra's mind before she can switch on to a different channel. Soon enough -- and before doing anything else -- she takes a few candies from the snack pile, places them between her and her wife, and pushes them all closer to the center similar to how it's often done with poker chips in the movies. "Bet you ten candies the next channel's gonna be about water -- or something related to it, at least." She meets Adora's gaze and grins, winking in the process.

Adora accepts the bet with a nod and collects some stray sweets for her to use next, all while biting back her smile in an attempt at making herself seem more like a professional. She then takes the remote and closes her eyes before pressing the button, though the audio by itself reveals what the channel -- or rather, commercial -- is about. The one on screen talks fast as he tries to fit as much information as he can into what looks like a cheap and old water filter with the most basic functions possible. Not even the enthusiastic voice nor the smile the man tries to maintain can help cover the fact it's a relatively faulty water filter like any other knockoff, but labeled as a unique product from his company.

Both women group the candy pieces together and chuckle when they realize how silly it is to have bet on the same thing.

Thankfully, Adora sets the next bet, one where they have differing thoughts on. Their improvised game continues until they're both out of candy to place further bets on and ends when they're both too full to eat what little's left. No savoury snacks remain and only two small piles of sweets stay waiting.

The two nearly synchronize as they reach out for the candy piles. One takes the other's favourite, and -- with shy smiles -- they unwrap the candies and feed them to each other, giggling midway. It's an unplanned situation gone right and inspires them both to smile, relax, and forget about problems that can't be solved just yet.

They share a kiss, motivated by the weight that's lifted off their shoulders.

Chapter End Notes

And that's it... For now!

See you all on December. :)

Chocolate

The following morning, Adora and Catra are woken up by the sudden, shrill sound of Adora's phone ringing, breaking the calm and silence of the hotel room.

In the blur of having just woken up, she holds back a yawn and answers without checking to see who it is, though the annoyed voice that rings through is easy enough to identify.

"I've got no patience left anymore, so just…" The woman on the other line trails off like she's still *barely* getting to process the information on her own. "So just listen to what I've got, and I'll tell you the rest later, okay?"

Adora replies when a mumbled, drowsy 'sure', then stays quiet while Catra lays a gentle hand on her shoulder, waiting.

"We found out who did this, and…"

The result of Mermista's investigation is, frankly put, anticlimactic.

Though just as much relieving, too.

She mentions she already dealt with the situation, and that she'll provide all of the details later, so as to not worry them and ruin their anniversary any further.

"Long story short, it'll be fine, we'll fix this, and it's not the end of the world," Mermista elaborates, and Adora can almost imagine her rolling her eyes. "But the people responsible for this *sure* make it look like it, so Sea Hawk's doing me a favour and holding them back until we can get them to clean up their mess."

Finally, the call ends with Adora thanking Mermista for the update, and with Catra asking for a summary of what happened.

"I'll tell you what she said while we get ready," Adora says, smiling at her persistent wife like she's trying to communicate everything's alright through that sole expression. "We've got nothing to worry about."

She laughs when Catra narrows her gaze like she doesn't believe her.

"At least… That's what Mermista said," she remarks, setting her hand on the one Catra's left on her shoulder. "We'll be okay."

"Promise?" Catra asks.

Adora replies with a nod and a squeeze to her hand.

“Promise,” she replies.

Catra reluctantly draws her hand back when Adora sets her device by the nightstand and gets out of bed.

A bedhead sticks to Adora's hair, currently let down so it reaches a little below her waist.

She looks as beautiful as she does each day, though…

Catra notices something odd poking out of Adora's messy locks.

“Uh,” she says, as smooth as an ocean wave. “Stay put. You've got something on your hair.”

Despite what Catra's said, Adora turns to her and asks what's up.

With the movement, what was stuck to her hair sticks out more, and it drops to the floor with a soft ‘plop’.

Adora bends to pick it up, while Catra walks to her side to see what it is.

"...What?" they say, in unison.

As if rehearsed, both women laugh when they stare at what Adora's picked up in her palm.

It's an empty, fun-sized chocolate wrapper.

"Wait," Catra says, as if realizing something. "You don't think…"

Still in sync, they both turn their heads towards the bed to see the mess left on it.

Multiple, colourful wrappers are sprinkled over the bedsheets like confetti after a party. Most of them once belonged to sweets, though there's the occasional bag of chips interrupting the pattern. There's a small bunch of gummies dispersed under Catra's pillow, squished into the fabric after a long night's sleep underneath them.

Catra notices and twists her shoulder to look over it and check her back.

And, in between goofy giggles, Adora confirms Catra's got a few gummies stuck to her shirt.

“Shower or clean up first?” she asks, though it's obvious what they need to do first.

Catra slips her shirt off and grins, throwing the garment on the floor.

“Definitely shower,” she replies, ruffling up Adora's hair. “Wanna go first, or do you wanna shower together?”

Shopping

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Several years later — just as televisions, phones, and cars were introduced as life in Etheria became peaceful once more — shopping malls are the newest craze, and Adora and Catra are busy preparing everything for the child they have on the way.

Finn, as both agreed on naming them, would have the best family they could dream of, with so many people willingly wanting to be their aunts, uncles, grandmas, and grandpas.

“What do you think?” Catra asks, holding up a light green baby onesie with little daisies all around.

“Cute!” Adora replies, beaming at her. “What about this?”

She holds up a tiny pair of white and light blue boots, and Catra chuckles at the sight.

They've been shopping since…

Who knows?

As soon as they both stepped into the shop, they'd lost track of the time.

To them, it feels like only minutes have passed.

Realistically, several hours have gone by.

“Wanna go somewhere else after this?” Catra asks, when Adora finishes today's shopping by throwing an extra pair of tiny boots in the cart. “Maybe the movies?”

Adora nods and smiles, pushing the cart forward while Catra helps by tugging it at the front.

“Anything specific you have in mind?” Adora asks in return, stopping when they reach the checkout counter. “Or do you want me to pick?”

“Wait,” Catra says, just when the tall clerk lady behind the counter is about to stash a pair of boots away in a bag. “Let the boots decide.”

“The boots?” Adora's confused tone is made clearer by a raised eyebrow and a mild frown. “How?”

Catra grins brightly and holds up the boots like they're a quest item.

"If they fall upright, I pick," she explains. "If they fall backwards, you pick!"

They both giggle at how silly that sounds, then pay up and walk away from the checkout counter to avoid bothering other shoppers.

Both women exit the store and sit on an empty bench, courtesy of people being too hyped up with all the shops to bother sitting or slowing down.

"Alright."

Adora holds her breath as Catra picks up the boots and prepares to throw them into the air.

"One…"

She lifts the boots off her lap.

"Two…"

She grabs the boots tighter, ready for the impulse.

“Three!”

She throws the pair of boots into the sky, then watches as they twirl in the air, landing on her lap, and...

“Backwards,” Adora exclaims, grinning. “I won!”

They both laugh again, though now, Adora leans on Catra's shoulder when the laughter dies down.

She closes her eyes and lets out a sigh, relaxing her body and loosening her hold on the bags she keeps dangling by the side of the bench.

Her stomach grumbles, as does her wife's.

“...Wanna eat lunch first?”

They look into each other's eyes and smile about as warm as the sensation in their chests feels.

“I'll pick which place,” Catra states, winking. “How about it?”

“As long as it's quick,” Adora replies, giggling. “I'm starving.”

On cue, they stand up and fix the bags hanging on their arms, then walk along hand in hand towards the food court, a brief and comfortable silence remaining throughout.

Chapter End Notes

Updates will be weekly on Mondays from here on out!

Only 3 more chapters left until the story ends. :)

Flowers

With the clothes and room all set for Finn, Adora and Catra now have more time to spare, yet…

With how busy they've been these past few months, they feel strange, having *that* much time to themselves.

Adora, thankfully, has an idea in mind — one that she's been considering ever since Perfuma gave her a plant to look after.

“Maybe we can…”

So much as *thinking* about making the suggestion feels silly, but she strongly believes Catra will agree, even without explaining.

“What's up?” Catra asks, before she can get her thoughts in order.

Adora follows Catra out of Finn’s room, then they reach the living room and sit down on the couch together.

“You look like you're… thinking a lot,” Catra pushes on, furrowing her gaze at Adora and setting a hand on her shoulder.

“Is everything okay?”

The blonde sighs and smiles, albeit weakly.

Then, she shakes her head and places her hand on top of the one that's on her shoulder.

“I'm okay,” she replies, avoiding her gaze for a split second to think back on her suggestion. “It's just… I was thinking that…” She wonders how her wife will react, and if she will take this as seriously as *she* wants to. “Maybe we can start a garden?”

Her chest thumps right as that question leaves her mouth.

She worries it's too much, and that maybe she's being too pushy, considering they've only just recently managed to finish Finn's room.

Adora, after so much peace and tranquility, now worries too much over too little, and Catra notices that quickly.

“Is that all?” the brunette asks, raising an eyebrow. “I thought it was something bad!” She huffs. “I thought maybe you were sick or something, but that's all?!”

Catra holds Adora by both of her shoulders, frowning when she makes eye contact.

“Why’re you so worried?” She squeezes Adora's shoulders and deepens her frown when she sees her tense up. “Of course, we can make a garden! What made you think I would say no?”

Adora's body eases when Catra pulls her into a hug. She sniffles and sobs, then holds her tighter, like she wants to communicate all of her worries at once. It isn't until Catra kisses her forehead that Adora realizes this isn't just about the garden, but a whole bunch of other things, topped one after the other so they've now come crashing down on her all at once.

“We’ve been busy,” she explains, her chest falling as she sighs. “You look tired, so I thought, maybe…”

Catra squeezes her hand, and that's all that it takes for Adora to smile and regain a little more confidence.

“I thought you'd say it was too soon, and that we should focus on resting first.”

Whatever else she's about to say, she isn't allowed to.

Catra's next hug is much too strong, and Adora fears she might start to feel dizzy if her wife continues to embrace her so

strongly.

"That's important, too, but…" She squeezes her again, making her let out a hitched gasp. "*You're* more important."

Catra lets her go, and Adora closes her eyes when she leans in, pecking her lips.

"Next time you have something on your mind, don't hold yourself back, okay?" Catra grins, and Adora giggles when she's kissed in the crook of her neck. "We'll always find a solution — one way or the other, and no matter how silly you think it is."

Intersection

“Ugh,” Catra says, groaning. “I can't believe I'll be late to my own kid’s birthday party!”

As Etheria gets more and more advanced, new problems surface.

And — though the pros usually outweigh the cons — today, Catra believes each and every advancement has led to the trouble she’s facing today.

It's Finn's seventh birthday, and now that roads and cars have been more widely introduced, Catra's currently stuck in heavy traffic.

“It's okay,” Adora assures her, voice gentle. “They already know what happened, and they're playing with their aunties while you get here!”

“Perfuma and Scorpia?”

Adora replies with a ‘yeah!’, then asks if she has the gift for the couple's anniversary next week.

“Already got it with me.”

“Alright! See you later.”

As soon as Adora hangs up, Catra sighs and rests her head on the wheel a little, careful not to make it honk.

“Mom,” Finn calls out, the very second Catra steps in. “You're back!”

Adora follows right behind them, with a big smile on her face, while Perfuma and Scorpia sit on the largest couch of the living room.

“See?” Adora taunts, a more smug smile sticking to her face as she jabs Catra on her hip. “Told you it wouldn't be too late!”

Finn giggles while Adora shows Catra her phone.

“Only five minutes late,” she states, tone abysmally proud. “Nobody's even here yet!”

Her gaze wanders back to the two women sitting on the couch.

"...Except Finn's aunties, of course," she adds, grinning at them.

Catra laughs, then places a hand on Adora's head, ruffling it up a little.

"Cute," she comments, picking a daisy amidst all the ones pinned to her blonde locks. "Did Perfuma help you?"

"She did most of the work," Adora admits, glancing at the couch again. "And Scorpia did the braid!"

Nodding, Catra takes the braid in her palm and stares at it for a while.

Her eyes narrow, and Adora frowns when her wife keeps herself silent.

"Um…"

More silence follows, and even Finn stares at the scene in confusion.

But then, Catra's cheeks tint red, and Adora immediately smiles at the sight.

“Aw, you think I look *adora*ble, don't y—”

Adora is cut off by Catra closing her eyes and pressing a kiss to her braid.

“You do,” she says, then makes eye contact with Perfuma, who's wiggling her eyebrows.

Scorpia, on the other hand, chuckles and rests her head against her partner's.

“Do you have more flowers?” Catra asks, her tone the slightest bit bashful. “I'd like to match.”

“Me— Me, too,” Finn chimes in, raising their hand like they're volunteering to answer a question at school. “Please!”

Perfuma stands up, lifting the ends of her dress.

“Well…” she trails off, grinning. “Since you asked so nicely…” She offers her hand to Scorpia. “We'll make it quick — before more quests show up, so go get your hair ready while we search for the flowers!”

Finn nods eagerly, grabs Catra's hand, and practically drags her upstairs, making Adora giggle at the sight.

“C’mon, mom,” they exclaim, beaming. “We're gonna look beautiful with momma!”

Domestic

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Many years pass, and now, Finn has graduated from highschool.

They moved out to start their life at college just last weekend, while this weekend, Catra and Adora have planned a road trip to Perfuma and Scorpia's new home.

The trip is eight hours long, so they've agreed to make a stop after two hours of driving, at a cozy-looking log motel nestled between a community park and a tiny grocery store.

"Dibs on the beanbag," Catra exclaims, rushing up to the living room as soon as Adora pushes the door open.

The inside of the room is about twice as cozy as the outside: a small beige loveseat, a wooden coffee table in front of it, coupled with a flat screen television and a yellow beanbag next to it. There isn't a kitchen per se, but there's a fridge, a sink, and a tall pantry filled with silverware, plates, bowls, and cups, all of that divided by a short and narrow hallway. At the very end of the hallway, there are two doors: one leading to the bedroom, and the other to the bathroom. The light of that path is dim, yet light pours more from the open doors.

While Catra has chosen to leave her luggage right next to the door and throw herself on the worn beanbag she claimed as hers, Adora drags hers further inside and glances around a bit more.

She notices the paintings of landscapes on the walls, and several potted plants decorating otherwise empty corners of each room. Most of the plants are pretty well-kept, though some are a little wilted. The soil looks dry for all of them, and some are overgrown.

Adora jogs off to the kitchen sink and grabs a cup from the pantry, filling it with water.

“Want me to help?”

At the absolute suddenness of Catra's arrival next to her, she jolts, squeaks, and ends up splashing the water right at her own face.

“Yes,” she says with a huff, wiping her face dry with a palm. “...By not sneaking up on me like that anymore.”

Catra chuckles and slips her shirt off, left only with her sports bra on and using the shirt to dry Adora's face properly.

Her wife's eyes wander to the muscles on her abdomen, then quickly look elsewhere.

“Like what you see?” Catra taunts, grinning.

Adora rolls her eyes and hides her blush by taking the shirt and covering the lower half of her face with it.

“Show off,” she retorts, glaring at the shirt. “You just wanted me to see how much you've been training, didn't you?”

She makes eye contact, a smug smile complimenting the mischievous glint in her eyes.

Not one for turning down a challenge, Catra crosses her arms and tilts her head to the side.

“Maybe,” she replies, widening her grin. “So, you've noticed?”

Adora's smile shifts to one of mirth as she lets out a laugh.

“Hard not to.”

The two share a laugh and savour the moment for as long as it lasts, which…

Doesn't feel all that long.

“Let's go take care of those plants,” Catra says and takes another cup, then grabs the accidentally emptied one and fills both of them with water.

“Aren’t you gonna get changed first?” Adora asks, raising an eyebrow.

“Nah.” Catra winks. “You can watch a little longer, unless you feel like you're gonna get bored of me.”

Adora shakes her head but still gives into smiling wide, taking a cup afterwards.

“I’ll *never* get bored of you, Applesauce.”

The two women walk up to the hallway, stopping midway.

“And *I* never will, either, Dora.”

Chapter End Notes

That's all, folks!

Thank you for reading, and take care. <3

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